

A controversial figure in his lifetime and since, Ngo Dinh Diem became the prime minister of South Vietnam in the wake of the 1954 partition of the country. Supported by the United States, Diem was a Vietnamese nationalist with a staunchly anticommunist and pro-Catholic worldview. While his regime saw myriad challenges and instability, the United States would ultimately regret its decision to orchestrate his downfall in 1963.

Like his adversary Ho Chi Minh, Diem was born into the traditional mandarin elite of Annam in central Vietnam. The Ngo family combined Confucianism with Catholicism, a minority belief in Vietnam. Diem followed the path of chastity as if he were a Catholic priest—but instead of entering the Church he pursued a bureaucratic career under Bao Dai, the Vietnamese emperor, who ruled in Annam under French control. Soon enough, Diem achieved recognition for his outstanding abilities, and he rose quickly through the ranks of the imperial civil service.

Despite Diem's position, he was a committed opponent of French colonialism. In 1933—when Emperor Bao Dai appointed him minister of the interior in the Annamese government—Diem proposed the introduction of a representative assembly, which would be a significant step toward self-government. However, when the reforms were blocked, Diem resigned, denouncing Bao Dai as “nothing but an instrument in the hands of the French.”